responsibility' is certainly singular and different from every other ruler of ancient India.[56] The argument is that the exception grows out of the norm and takes shape as exemplary form.

The modern scholarly fascination with Ashoka and the changing contours of research on him are evident in many other writings but my intention is not to explore them in all their nuances. An excellent guide to the range and richness of Ashokan studies can be found in Harry Falk's bibliography, *Asokan Sites and Artefacts*, which contains nearly 1800 entries.[57] All the big names of ancient Indian studies figure there—James Prinsep, Georg Buhler, Emile Senart, Radhakumud Mookerji, Romila Thapar, Dines Chandra Sircar, P.H.L. Eggermont, Kenneth Roy Norman, Awadh Kishore Narain, Patrick Olivelle, and Dilip Kumar Chakrabarti, to name a few. The bibliography lists hundreds of books and articles about Ashoka's epigraphs, several of which contain their texts and translations; others are expositions on various elements of the scripts and languages used, as well as on similarities and variations in the different versions of the inscriptions.

Writings on other aspects of Ashoka are no less impressive and include accounts of the art and architectural features of his various monuments; the diverse archaeology and historical geography of Ashokan sites; the emperor's ideas on public ethics, spiritual victory, the rights of living beings, human and animal; the image of Ashoka in the literature of Asia; comparisons between the edicts and texts like the *Bhagavadgita* and the *Indica* of Megasthenes; the personality of Ashoka; the fascinating story of the discovery of the epigraphs and of the emperor in them; and so much else.

Having read a fair range of these writings, I am inclined to put myself in the shoes of my readers to ask once again: Why another book on Ashoka? What makes this one different from the others?